that the trip remain secret and that there be no defectors. Monitoring the attitudes of officers and men regarding Soviet policy toward Cuba was part of the KGB's job, and what they uncovered was anything but reassuring to Khrushchev and his team. The KGB officers' reports to headquarters after the voyage indicated that unlike Pismenny, who called Cuba "the island of my soul" and was excited about the assignment, many of his fellow sailors as well as military personnel were anything but volunteers and had generally been dispatched to Cuba against their wishes.

"It's offensive that our fate was decided somewhere over a glass of vodka, and we have to pay the bill by heading off to Cuba, which is of no use to anybody," wrote an officer to his wife before departure. Not only had he criticized the government and questioned its policies, but he had also divulged a secret about his destination. The letter was intercepted by the KGB and brought to the attention of the officer's senior commanders, but they decided to send him to Cuba anyway "in the hope that after appropriate explanatory work he will understand the need to help the young Cuban republic." Captain Sizov, who was traveling to Cuba on the *Nikolai Burdenko*, was even more outspoken. "We're being taken for slaughter," he told a fellow officer who turned out to be a KGB informer. "I'm ready to lose my party card as long as I get back to the Union," continued Sizov, who was deputy head of his unit's party cell. "The best thing to do on encountering Americans is to surrender and be taken prisoner."[14]

More than one thousand soldiers and five hundred officers were found unfit for the assignment for a variety of reasons. Some of the soldiers, once they learned about the forthcoming trip abroad (many suspected that the destination would be Cuba), tried to disqualify themselves by getting into trouble with their superiors, including going AWOL. Especially unhappy were the soldiers whose three-year term of mandatory military service was coming to an end in the summer of 1962: deployment to Cuba meant that their return home was indefinitely postponed. In some cases, commanders tried to ship troublemakers to Cuba. Private Borisov, having ridden drunkenly around Sevastopol on a stolen police bicycle, was arrested and put on a Cuba-bound vessel. Borisov resisted arrest and was probably beaten up by the military police: he would spend ten days, or most of the voyage, in a hospital bed, reported KGB major Verbov.[15]